The death sentence for Geelani shocked the people of Kashmir and they declared a bandh for three days. Hundreds in Kashmir sent postcards to the home minister and the National Human Rights Commission demanding a fair trial for Geelani and the other three accused, insisting that if Geelani got a fair trial he would be acquitted. In the rest of the country too people demanded a fair trial, even if ambivalent about Geelani's innocence.

The media neither supported this campaign nor reported on its growing momentum. For them, the fact that more than 50,000 postcards had been sent from across the country demanding a fair trial was not news. Apart from the three universities in Delhi, the Defence Committee for S.A.R. Geelani got support from the university community of West Bengal.[5] The All Bengal University Teachers Association, representing nine universities, passed a resolution in Geelani's support. With the help of our website, pamphlets, posters, meetings and alternative media in regional languages we reached more than 100,000 people. The campaign also got the support of individuals and organizations abroad—from Amnesty International to Noam Chomsky.[6]

The fact that Ram Jethmalani, senior counsel and former union law minister, offered to defend Geelani pro bono greatly boosted our campaign. Ram Jethmalani argued with passion and conviction. He told the high court judges hearing the case that Geelani did not get even a moment's fair trial in the lower court, that he had taken up the case because he was morally convinced that Geelani was innocent and there was no evidence against him. The campaign for Geelani's release, along with Ram Jethmalani's passionate defence, succeeded in getting Geelani's acquittal.

The acquittal was hailed as a triumph of Indian democracy. Newspapers across the country carried editorials proclaiming that justice had been done. For some, the judgement reflected the competence and independence of our judiciary. Others, who had lost hope in Indian secularism in the aftermath of the Gujarat riots and the rising tide of communal prejudice, felt that this judgement of the Delhi High Court had vindicated their faith in Indian secularism. Still others felt that it reflected the vibrancy of our democratic institutions.

There were those who read the news of the acquittal with an indescribable happiness, similar to what one experiences after a miracle. Friends who had lost touch with me for more than fifteen years called to express their joy. In a manner of speaking, the judgement is a miracle. How many of us really